

Topic: Research methods in Sociology

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Research Methods in Sociology

Survey method

Survey is a systematic way of asking people to provide information about their attitudes, behaviors, opinions, beliefs, social conditions and relationships on a specific issue.

Babbie (2007) said that “ Survey research is probably the best method available to the social researcher who is interested in collecting original data for describing a population too large to observe directly.”

Types of Survey

- i. Questionnaire survey
- ii. Interview survey

Types of Questionnaire

- i. Open-ended questionnaire
- ii. Close-ended questionnaire

Case study method

“The case study method is a very popular form of qualitative analysisIt is a method of study in depth rather than breadth...the object of the case study method is to locate the factors that account for the behavior-pattern of the given unit as an Integrated totality (Kothari, 1985).”

Pauline V. Young describes case study as “ a comprehensive study of a social unit be that unit a person, a group, a social institution, a district or a community.”

Ethnography Method

- Ethnography is a qualitative research method in which a researcher uses participant observation and interviews in order to gain a deeper understanding of a group's culture.
- Ethnographies are an in depth study of the way of life of a group of people in their natural settings.
- It documents routine daily lives of people(Fetterman, 1998).
- Explores a cultural group.
- Lives with people, or spends a lot of time with them.

Participant Observation Method

Participant observation is a data collection technique that requires that researcher to be present at, involved in, and recording the routine daily activities with people in the field setting (Schensul et.al.,1999).

Longitudinal Studies

Longitudinal studies of a sample of people in which information is collected from the same people at intervals over a long period of time. For example, a researcher might start off in 2014 by getting a sample of 1000 people to fill in a questionnaire, and then go back to the same people in 2019, and again in 2024 to collect further information.

Focus Group Discussion

A focus group discussion involves gathering people from similar backgrounds or experiences together to discuss a specific topic of interest. It is a form of qualitative research where questions are asked about their perceptions, attitudes, beliefs, opinion or ideas. In focus group discussion participants are free to talk with other group members; it encourages discussions with other participants. It generally involves group interviewing in which a small group of usually 8 to 12 people. It is led by a moderator (interviewer) in a loosely structured discussion of various topics of interest.